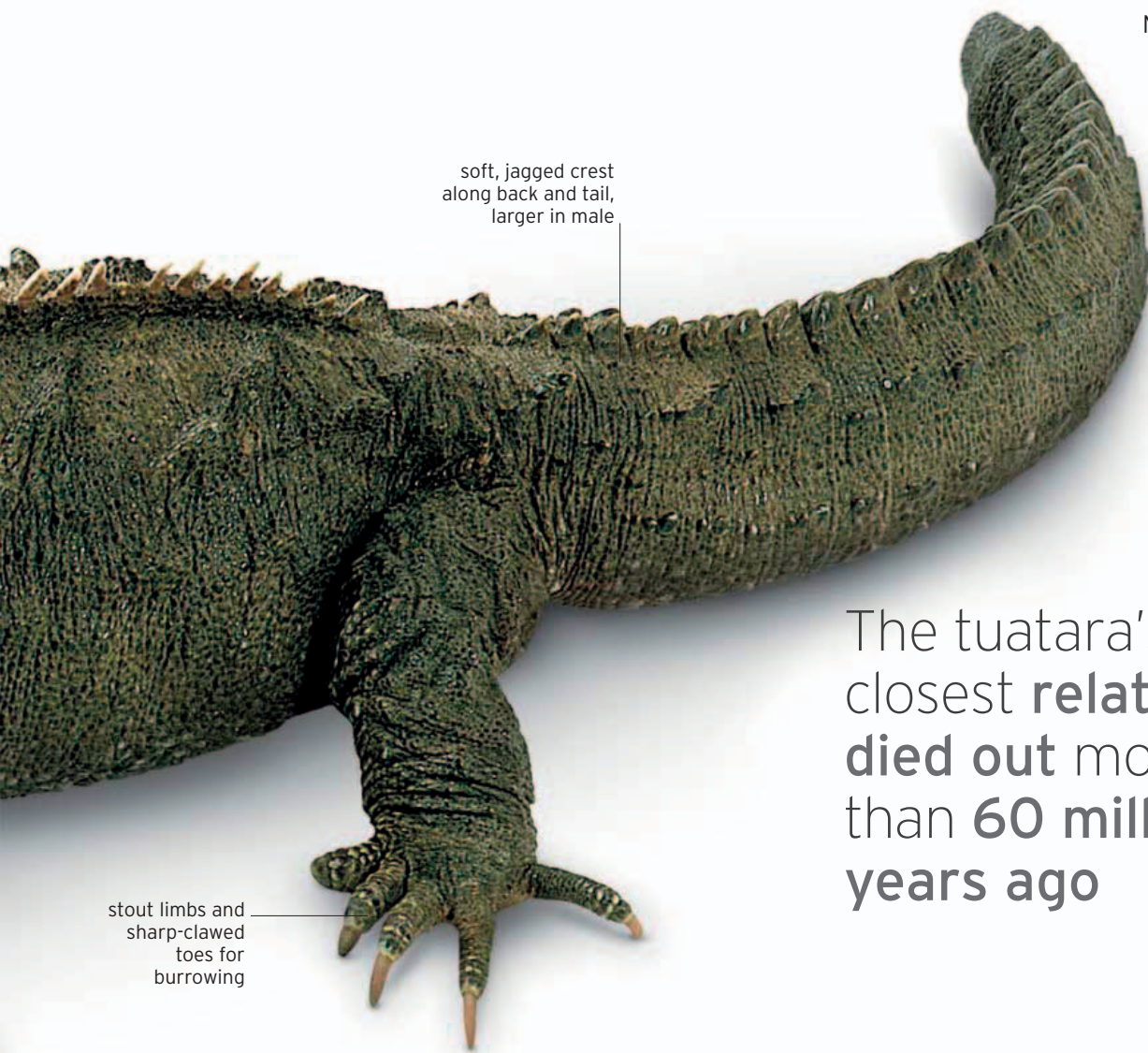




soft, jagged crest
along back and tail,
larger in male

stout limbs and
sharp-clawed
toes for
burrowing

The tuatara's
closest **relatives**
died out more
than **60 million**
years ago

- ↔ 20–24 in (51–61 cm)
- ⚖ 7/8–2 lb (0.4–1 kg)
- ⊗ Locally common
- 🕸 Spiders, insects, worms
- 🏠 🌿 🌳



New Zealand
(coastal islands)



△ BONY TEETH

The sharp teeth are fused to the jaw bone and are not shed and regrown as in most other reptiles.

Blue damselfly

Austrolestes colenisonis

The largest damselfly in New Zealand, the blue damselfly can be seen fluttering around reeds and rushes in areas of still water. Frequently confused with dragonflies, damselflies are less powerful fliers and hold their wings along the body, rather than out sideways, when at rest. The blue damselfly can change color to control its temperature—the blue males and greener females turn darker when the weather is cold in order to absorb more heat from their surroundings.

Aerial hunters

Adult damselflies live only for a couple of weeks. They are aerial hunters, snatching smaller insects, using their enormous round eyes to track moving targets. Mating couples can be seen flying together over still water—the male guards the female as she lays her eggs, ensuring no other mate is able to copulate with her. The nymphs spend the winter underwater, breathing with gills that are located on the tip of their abdomen. They hunt on the bottom using a specialized mouthpart to skewer prey. In spring, the wingless nymphs climb out of the water to molt into the adult form.



wings point backward at rest



- ↔ 2 in (5 cm)
- ⊗ Common
- 🕸 Water fleas
- 🏠 🌿 🌳



New Zealand

◁ LOVER'S EMBRACE

During mating the male clasps the female just behind her head and she then reaches around with her flexible abdomen to accept a packet of sperm from him.